Bengal (520 km). The Ganga basin covers about 8.6 lakh sq. km area in India alone.

The Ganga initially flows in the southern direction, then in the south-east direction up to Mirzapur and then in the east direction in the Bihar plains. Near the Rajmahal hills, it turns into south-east direction and after flowing some distance in Murshidabad district of West Bengal, it enters Bangladesh. In Bangladesh, it gets divided into two main distributaries- the Bhagirathi and the Hugli. The main river goes to Bangladesh where it is firstly known by the name of the Padma and then the Meghna which drains into the Bay of Bengal.

57. The Son is a large south bank tributary of the Ganga, originating in the Amarkantak plateau. After forming a series of waterfalls at the edge of the plateau, it reaches Arrah, west of Patna, to join the Ganga.

Its source is close to the origin of the Narmada. It passes along the Kaimur Range.

It flows for a distance of 784 km from its source.

The important tributaries of the Son are the Johilla, the Gopat, the Rihand, the Kanhar and the North Koel. Almost all the tributaries join it on its right bank.

58. Kerala has a narrow coastline. The longest river of Kerala, Bharathapuzha rises near Annamalai hills. It is also known as Ponnani. It drains an area of 5397 sq. km. Compare its catchment area with that of the Sharavati river of Karnataka. The Periyar is the second largest river of Kerala. Its catchment area is 5243 sq. km. You can see that there is a marginal difference in the catchment area of the Bhartapuzha and the Periyar rivers. Another river of Kerala worth mentioning is the Pamba river which falls in the Vemobana lake after traversing a course of 177 km.

59. The Peninsular drainage system is older than the Himalayan one. This is evident from the broad, largely-graded shallow valleys, and the maturity of the rivers. The Western Ghats running close to the western coast act as the water divide between the major Peninsular rivers, discharging their water in the Bay of Bengal and as small rivulets joining the Arabian Sea. Most of the major